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MVA (INDIA BLOC)

STRENGTHS

- Perceived sympathy for Sharad Pawar and Uddhav Thackeray, and anger at *ayaram-gayaram* politics
- The split in the Shiv Sena and the NCP's legislative wings is not translating into a migration of voters on the ground
- Support of smaller players like the Peasants and Workers Party, who have pockets of influence
- New social combinations and the support of the majority of the minorities
- Pent-up anti-incumbency against the state government

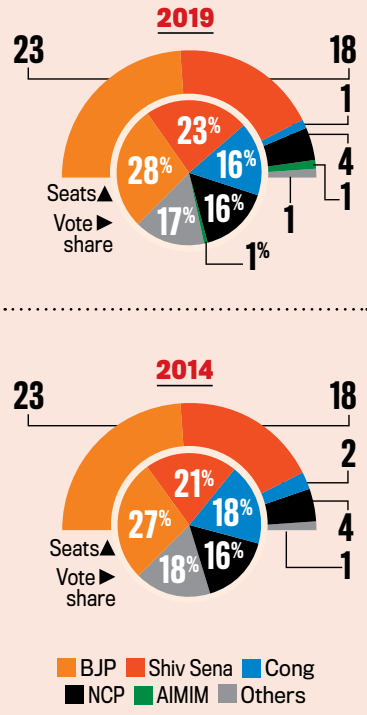
WEAKNESSES

- Unease in the Congress over the Sena (UBT) and NCP (SCP) walking away with party strongholds
- A string of defections by local and middle-rung leaders to the Mahayuti
- Vulnerability with regard to co-ordination between the cadre of the three principal constituents
- Inability to strike the right notes in the Maratha-OBC clash over quotas
- Questions over whether the Sena (UBT) cadre will vote for the Congress or NCP (SCP) in seats where the BJP is in the fray

A LOOK AT THE PAST

LOK SABHA

Total seats: 48



Vote share figures have been rounded off

too are on opposite sides: a lifelong Bal Thackeray devout like Shinde has technically won the patent to his legacy, but in service of the BJP-led ruling coalition, of which he's the chief minister. A Pawar Sr acolyte like Praful Patel is now against him. Former foes like Ajit Pawar and the other deputy CM, BJP leader Devendra Fadnavis, now confer in the same corner.

With a kingdom too at stake, no one would think it hyperbole to call this a Mahabharata. In fact, with a Mahayuti alliance up against a Maha Vikas Aghadi, the prefix 'Maha' (grand) applies across the board in Maharashtra. How the sundry players in these two formations fare will determine the fate of the even grander alliances they are faces of—the NDA and the Opposition's Indian National Developmental Inclusive Alliance, or INDIA.

For all the seeming contradictions, this perhaps represents an interim stage in an evolving polity. It was in 2014 that the state's traditional Congress-oriented dominance was shattered when the BJP-Sena combine swept 42 seats, and several veterans from the Congress and NCP bit the dust. The saffron alliance also came to power in the assembly election held a few months later, and then pulled off a near-repeat of its Lok Sabha show in 2019, before

IT'S THE SENSE THAT THIS IS A CASE OF STOLEN IDENTITY THAT HAS GIVEN THE MVA ITS MOST POTENT PLANK—A STRONG REGIONAL NARRATIVE TO BEAT BACK THE MAHAYUTI

the twister hit. But amidst all the play of numbers, a subtle realignment of ideologies was also unfolding. Uddhav, leading the Sena since the death of his father in 2012, was made of a perceptibly different persuasion. A photography enthusiast with a taste for nature, he was gentler of speech and thought. While never abandoning the centrality of Maharashtrian pride to Sena politics, the bristling Hindutva demagoguery slowly receded from the main stage. This face became more apparent post-2019, after his split with the BJP, when he ran a fairly equitable regime for over two and a half years. Rather than a contradiction within a secular alliance, he seemed a comfortable fit. But he still drew his popular legitimacy from the old Sena legacy, and that's what was threatened with the BJP-sponsored Eknath Shinde rebellion of June 2022.

But the biggest question in Maharashtra is, has the BJP unwittingly bol-